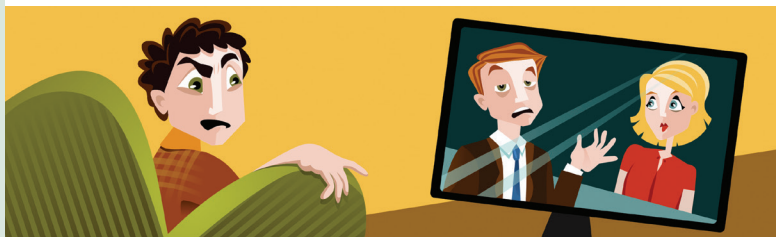


A

Political interviews

- Interviewer: Despite the fact that you **gave repeated assurances** that you would not raise taxes, you seem to have **broken your promise** and raised five different taxes. Can you **offer an explanation** for why this happened? Haven't you **betrayed the trust** of the voters?
- Politician: I **reject that charge** completely. We have **kept our manifesto promise** and not raised the basic rate of income tax at all.
- Interviewer: Yes, but you've raised indirect taxes instead, so, in effect, you've **gone back on¹ your promise** of no tax increases, have you not?
- Politician: No. We **made a commitment** with regard to the basic rate of income tax. And I'm happy to **reaffirm² that commitment** now. The basic rate will remain unchanged ...

These politicians! They can never **give a straight³ answer!**
They're great at **dodging⁴ the question.**



¹ not kept, or changed in some way

² strongly state again

³ direct and honest

⁴ avoiding

B

Discussing communication

- Tutor: Right. I want to **put** the following **question** to you: do you think the **channels of communication** between politicians and the people are adequate?
- (The students are silent.)
- Tutor: Well, let me **frame¹ the question** differently. Do politicians genuinely communicate directly with the public? Zoë, what do you think?
- Zoë: Not really. It's just soundbites on TV, isn't it? They hardly ever meet ordinary people face to face. They don't mind **fielding² questions** from journalists, they're used to that, but that's not the same as **confronting the issues** directly with real people.
- Tutor: Well, that's a **fair comment**. But what about politicians who have websites and write blogs? Are these better ways of **establishing communication** with people? Young people don't watch TV; they're on the web all the time.
- Paul: **With all due respect³**, I think you're **missing the point⁴**, if you don't mind me saying so. The politicians can still keep their distance. They don't have to **face a grilling⁵** from journalists or anyone if they just have a web page or a blog. In some ways it's worse than media interviews.
- Tutor: Fine. **I take your point⁶**. But no politician can meet everyone face to face, so communicating with as many people as possible using technology could be seen as more genuinely democratic, couldn't it?
- Imelda: Yes, but they become less accountable. If there's a scandal, they just **issue a denial**, and when did you last hear a politician **give a full apology** for getting things wrong? They **enter into a contract** with the people and if they **breach⁷ that contract** they should be directly accountable, and not just at election time.
- Tutor: Right. Okay then. Get into groups and discuss ways in which politicians can be made more directly accountable. Okay? About ten minutes.

¹ formulate

² dealing with

³ used before the speaker disagrees with or criticises the person they are addressing

⁴ misunderstanding the idea someone is expressing

⁵ face a lot of tough questions

⁶ accept that you have a serious opinion worth considering

⁷ break

Exercises

58.1 Match words from each box to form collocations and use them in the appropriate form to complete the sentences below.

reject	break
reaffirm	dodge
offer	betray

a promise	someone's trust
a question	a commitment
a charge	an explanation

- 1 He said he wouldn't tell anyone of my plans but he his and shared everything with his wife.
- 2 She was unable to any for what had happened.
- 3 I want to my to your scheme to help poorer families.
- 4 The minister the and denied he had misled the public.
- 5 Why do politicians always the and never give an honest answer?
- 6 The Prime Minister has the of those who elected her.

58.2 Rewrite the underlined part of each sentence using the words in brackets in the appropriate form in a collocation from the opposite page.

- 1 The school's director reassured everyone over and over again that the school was not going to close, despite reports in the press. (GIVE REPEAT)
- 2 Henry broke his promise to take part in our charity football match. (BACK)
- 3 Politicians rarely respond directly and honestly to a question. (STRAIGHT)
- 4 Philip said very firmly that he would support us. (COMMIT)
- 5 Thank you for doing what you promised to do. (KEEP)
- 6 The team manager gave quite skilful answers to a number of hostile questions from reporters after the match. (FIELD)
- 7 We need better ways of communicating with our customers. (CHANNEL)
- 8 I accept that you have a strong argument but it's a very complex problem. (TAKE)
- 9 He said he was 100 percent sorry for his behaviour. (GIVE FULL)

58.3 Read these remarks by different people, and then answer the questions.

Simon: I didn't quite know the best way to ask him what I wanted to know.

Arlene: I took more days off than I was officially allowed and was fired from my job.

Alex: I had to answer almost an hour of really difficult questions at the interview.

Finn: I couldn't sign an agreement with the builder because I didn't get the bank loan.

Brona: I didn't see what was important in what the lecturer was saying. Did you?

	name
1 Who faced a grilling?	
2 Who missed the point of something?	
3 Who had problems framing a question?	
4 Who breached a contract?	
5 Who didn't enter into a contract with someone?	

58.4 Make six collocations from these words and write a sentence using each.

confront	due	establish
fair	issue	put

comment	communication	denial
issue	question	respect